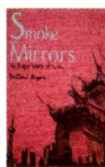


CHINESE TAKEAWAY

A well-informed and entertaining account of life in the Middle Kingdom that debunks Hindi-Chini stereotypes



SMOKE AND MIRRORS: AN EXPERIENCE OF CHINA
by PALLAVI AIYAR
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■ By Sunil Sethi

Impulsive choices in life can sometimes produce the best books. In 1981 Vikram Seth, then a research student at Nanjing University, managed through a combination of audacity and fluke to cross the overland route to Delhi through Sinkiang and Tibet. The result was *From Heaven Lake*, a memorable first book and the opening salvo in a meteoric literary career. In 2002, Pallavi Aiyar turned her back on a promising future in the media and went to China in pursuit of love: her Spanish boyfriend, whom she had met at the London School of Economics, was based in Beijing and persuaded her to join him. Two hundred years ago, he told her, Napoleon had prophesied that once the sleeping dragon awakened, the world would tremble. The dragon had woken up, he murmured, so make your move. It was a fortuitous decision: in time she married the man and stayed on to become an award-winning foreign correspondent—the only Chinese-speaking Indian journalist in China for more than five years. *Smoke and Mirrors* is by far the most well-informed and entertaining account of life in the Middle Kingdom by an Indian in recent years.

Aiyar's working life had three avatars in China: as a lowly-paid broadcast journalism teacher to students barely a few years younger than herself; as consultant to the CII, helping out with the growing number of Indian businessmen in China and Chinese trade delegations to India; and finally as fulltime journalist, on reporting assignments that took her further afield.

She travels from the factories of

Zhejiang in the south where local entrepreneurs, China's "Marwaris", have enriched villages by churning out 15 billion buttons, three billion pairs of socks, 70 per cent of the world's Christmas decorations and anything, from African art to statues of Ganesha, "made in China, and cheaper". She goes to Ningxia in the north, home to 1.8 million Hui Muslims, where an explosion of madrasas has made authorities promote the "competitive advantage" of Muslims by exporting *halal* meat to the Middle East. She hangs out with the abbot of Baimasi

years to complete.

As a literate, observant and witty travelling companion, Aiyar cuts through the economic jargon and political cant by recording people's voices and, at the same time, questioning her own assumptions. She starts married life by moving into a courtyard house in a *hutong*, one of the few village-like enclaves in a Capital convulsed by a bulldozing and building frenzy that echoes the exhortation of the Cultural Revolution: "Forget the old. Build the new." Through her daily interaction with neighbours, landlords, spoilt "little emperors" (a result of China's one-child policy) and the elderly trapped by the crack-up of urban communities, Aiyar peers into the nooks and crannies of Chinese life, debunking many of the pet theories held dear by "Chindia" specialists.

She compares the lot of the city's toilet cleaners to the lives of domestic sweepers at home just as the unthinking credulity of her students, shattered by the gravity of the SARS crisis, takes her back to the infectious anti-establishment arguments of campus life in India. Aiyar is gifted with a natural sense of the absurd; nowhere is this better on display than in chapters titled 'Hindi-Chini Buy Buy' and 'Chicken Feet and Jain Diets', in which she hilariously dissects the horror and revulsion that overtakes the two races when faced with one another's dietary preferences and material desires. In the end, like the pigs in Orwell's *Animal Farm*, she asks how a classless society became so unequal.

Smoke and Mirrors is scarred by sloppy usage and an inability to handle compound sentences. Aiyar's punctuation sucks. Commas, like reincarnated lamas, appear from nowhere and the semi-colon is as mysterious as the Manchurian Candidate. Still, it is an almost perfect read because it takes us into those hidden folds and crevices of life in China where angels fear to tread. ■



THE DRAGON'S LAIR: Aiyar takes us into the hidden folds of the country

temple in central Henan where, 2,000 years ago, Indian monks established the first Buddhist monastery in China. Later, by virtue of being one of three Indian journalists present, she gets on to the inaugural Beijing-Lhasa train, the \$4 billion (Rs 16,000 crore) railway line over the icy wastes of the Tibetan plateau that took one lakh workers five